

Computing for you

Software is programs that allow people to use a computer's hardware. Most computers come with pre-installed software, but additional pieces of software are also widely available.

System software

System software allows user applications to run on the computer's hardware. The operating system (OS) – which controls the computer's basic functions – is the most common example. It makes the computer work by displaying information on the screen and getting user input from the keyboard, touchscreen, or mouse. For computer security, it's important to install any updates that become available for the OS.

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Operating systems 44–45 ▶

Desktop computers and laptops 50–51 ▶

▽ Different operating systems

There are many operating systems available. Microsoft Windows and Linux are the most commonly used ones. Apple machines use a specific operating system, called macOS.

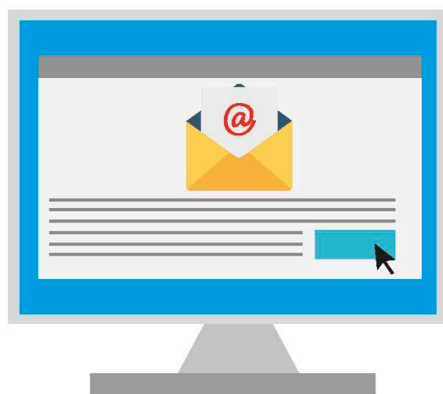
Windows

Linux

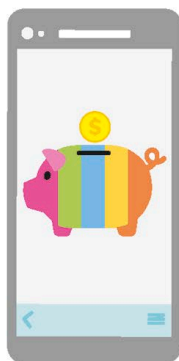
macOS

Application software

Application software is designed to complete specific tasks on a computer. Some of these are paid, as either a one-off purchase or a monthly subscription. Others may be free to download and use. A lot of free software is also open source, which enables users to see and modify the application's code.



Email



Banking

△ Different platforms

Application software is available for different types of device. Those used for mobile phones and tablets are usually known as apps. Apps can perform a variety of tasks, such as sending emails, social networking, and even banking.

IN DEPTH

Icons

Small symbols representing applications or functions on a computer are called icons. They make it easier for people to use their computer. Many functions are symbolized by similar icons across different operating systems – for instance, a floppy disk denoting the save option, or a magnifying glass symbolizing the search option.



Save



Volume



Settings



Trash